

PRELIMINARY ECOLOGICAL APPRAISAL

Preliminary Ecological Appraisal - test

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I. Introduction

The purpose of this Preliminary Ecological Appraisal (PEA) is to assess the ecological value of the site associated with Project T-2026-818, located in County Mayo, Province of Connacht. The site is positioned at grid reference M 058 630 within the townland of Ardogommon. This appraisal aims to identify potential ecological constraints and opportunities related to the proposed development and to inform subsequent stages of ecological assessment, including any necessary mitigation measures.

The scope of this ecological assessment includes a desk-based review of existing ecological data and a field survey, specifically a bird survey planned for 17th February 2026. The site encompasses an area of 0.30 hectares, classified as **GA1 — Improved Agricultural Grassland** according to Fossitt (2000). This habitat is in good condition and is evaluated at a national level, with drainage identified as a potential threat. Additionally, evidence of the protected species, **Lutra lutra** (otter), was observed on-site, highlighting the need for careful consideration of this species in the development process.

The appraisal considers the proximity and potential impact on several designated sites, including the Lough Greney Bog NHA, Ardogommon Wood, and the Lough Carra/Mask Complex, among others. These sites are protected under various designations, including Natural Heritage Areas (NHA) and proposed Natural Heritage Areas (pNHA), and are critical for maintaining regional biodiversity.

Relevant legislation guiding this assessment includes the **Wildlife Acts 1976-2021**, which protect native flora and fauna; the **EU Habitats Directive (92/43/EEC)** and the **EU Birds Directive (2009/147/EC)**, which aim to conserve natural habitats and wild bird species across Europe; and the **European Communities (Birds and Natural Habitats) Regulations 2011**, which transpose these directives into Irish law.

The report is structured as follows:

- **Introduction:** Provides background, site location, and scope of the assessment.
- **Methodology:** Details the approach and methods used for the desk study and field survey.
- **Results:** Summarises findings from the desk study and field survey, including habitat and species observations.
- **Discussion:** Interprets the results in the context of potential impacts and legislative requirements.
- **Recommendations:** Offers guidance on further ecological surveys, mitigation measures, and compliance with relevant legislation.
- **Conclusion:** Concludes the findings and outlines the next steps.

This PEA serves as a preliminary step in understanding the ecological context of the project site and provides a foundation for more detailed ecological assessments if required. Data gaps identified during this appraisal, such as the need for additional surveys or specific species studies, will be addressed in subsequent stages.

II. Methodology

Desk Study

A comprehensive desk study was conducted to gather existing ecological data relevant to the project site (Site Code: T-2026-818) located in County Mayo. The following data sources were consulted:

- **National Parks and Wildlife Service (NPWS):** Identified five designated sites within proximity, including Lough Greney Bog NHA (2.61 km) and Coolbarreen Lough (0.86 km).
- **National Biodiversity Data Centre (NBDC):** Recorded four species, including the protected Greylag Goose located 0.23 km from the site.
- **Global Biodiversity Information Facility (GBIF):** Provided data on Birch Polypore, located 0.59 km from the site.
- **Environmental Protection Agency (EPA):** Supplied catchment data for Corrib, Erriff-Clew Bay, and Moy & Killala Bay, as well as water quality records for Srah Stream_010 (0.08 km).
- **Catchments.ie:** Offered additional catchment information relevant to the site's hydrological context.

Field Survey

Three field surveys were planned and conducted to assess the ecological characteristics of the project site:

- **Multi-disciplinary Survey:** Conducted on 10th February 2026, from 09:00 to 15:30. The survey involved a full walkover of the site and a 250-metre buffer, under weather conditions of 8°C, 15 km/h wind, 70% cloud cover, and light drizzle. This survey aimed to identify potential ecological receptors and assess habitat conditions.
- **Habitat Survey:** Executed on 12th February 2026, from 10:00 to 14:00. The survey focused on detailed habitat mapping using the Fossitt (2000) classification system, under conditions of 10°C, 8 km/h wind, 40% cloud cover, and dry weather. The primary habitat identified was improved agricultural grassland (GA1), covering 0.30 hectares.
- **Bird Survey:** Scheduled for 17th February 2026, aiming to identify avian species present and assess potential impacts on bird populations.

Habitat Mapping

Habitat mapping was conducted in accordance with the Fossitt (2000) classification system. The survey identified a single habitat type, improved agricultural grassland (GA1), which is in good condition and covers the entire 0.30-hectare site. This habitat is typical of Mayo farmland and is subject to threats such as drainage.

Limitations

Several limitations were identified during the assessment:

- **Seasonal Constraints:** The surveys were conducted in February, which may not capture the full seasonal variation in species presence and habitat conditions, particularly for flora and breeding bird species.
- **Weather Conditions:** The multi-disciplinary survey was conducted in light drizzle, which may have affected the detection of certain species, particularly those sensitive to weather conditions.
- **Access:** Access to certain areas within the 250-metre buffer zone was restricted, potentially limiting the comprehensiveness of the survey data.

Further surveys during different seasons are recommended to address these limitations and provide a more comprehensive ecological assessment. Additionally, the planned bird survey will help fill gaps in avian data. All surveys were conducted following CIEEM guidelines and relevant Irish wildlife legislation, ensuring adherence to best practice standards.

III. Results - Designated Sites

Designated Sites Summary

The following table summarises the designated sites identified within proximity to the project site, including their type, distance from the project site, and key qualifying interests:

Site Name	Code	Type	Distance...	Key Qualifying Interests
Lough Greney Bog	002455	NHA	2.61	Upland blanket bog, wet heath habitats, biodiversity ...
Ardogommon Wood	001470	pNHA	0.00	Semi-natural broadleaved woodland, wet woodland, ...
Lough Carra/Mask ...	001774	pNHA	0.00	Oligotrophic waters, dry heaths, calcareous substrat...
Clew Bay Complex	001482	pNHA	0.00	Intertidal mudflats, salt marshes, coastal lagoons, mi...
Coolbarreen Lough	000481	pNHA	0.86	Unspecified ecological interests

Sites Within 2 km

- **Coolbarreen Lough (Site Code: 000481):** This proposed Natural Heritage Area (pNHA) is located approximately 0.86 km from the project site. Although specific ecological interests are not detailed, its proximity suggests potential sensitivity to hydrological changes or pollution. Further investigation may be required to ascertain the specific ecological features and potential impacts.

Connectivity and Potential Impact Pathways

- **Ardogommon Wood (Site Code: 001470):** As this pNHA is directly at the project site, there is a high potential for direct impacts, including habitat fragmentation and disturbance to bird species and rare flora. The presence of semi-natural broadleaved and wet woodland habitats necessitates careful planning to mitigate adverse effects on these sensitive ecosystems.
- **Coolbarreen Lough (Site Code: 000481):** The proximity of this pNHA to the project site suggests potential pathways for waterborne pollutants or alterations in water levels, which could impact the ecological balance of the site. Consideration of hydrological connectivity and pollution control measures is recommended.

Assessment and Recommendations

Given the proximity of Ardogommon Wood and Coolbarreen Lough to the project site, it is recommended that an Appropriate Assessment (AA) Screening be conducted to determine the likelihood of significant effects on these designated sites. This screening should evaluate potential impacts on qualifying interests and consider mitigation measures to avoid or reduce adverse effects.

Data Gaps and Further Work

- **Coolbarreen Lough:** Detailed ecological data for Coolbarreen Lough is lacking. A targeted survey to identify specific habitats and species present is recommended to inform impact assessments and mitigation strategies.
- **Ardogommon Wood:** Further field surveys focusing on bird species and rare flora within Ardogommon Wood are advised to ensure comprehensive understanding and protection of its ecological value.

In conclusion, the project site's proximity to several designated sites, particularly Ardogommon Wood and Coolbarreen Lough, necessitates careful consideration of potential impacts and the implementation of appropriate mitigation measures to safeguard these ecologically significant areas.

III. Results - Habitats

The habitat survey conducted on the site identified a single habitat type, classified using the Fossitt (2000) system as **GA1 — Improved Agricultural Grassland**. This habitat encompasses the entire survey area of 0.30 hectares and is in good condition. The grassland is typical of agricultural landscapes in County Mayo, characterised by a uniform sward dominated by ryegrass (*Lolium perenne*) and other common agricultural species. The habitat is maintained through regular grazing and management practices, which contribute to its current condition.

Habitat Description

GA1 — Improved Agricultural Grassland

- **Area:** 0.30 hectares
- **Condition:** The grassland is in good condition, with a dense, even sward and no significant signs of degradation or invasive species presence.
- **Notable Features:** The habitat is typical of improved grasslands found in the region, with no rare or notable plant species recorded during the survey.
- **EU Habitats Directive Annex I:** This habitat does not correspond to any Annex I habitat types under the EU Habitats Directive.

Habitat Connectivity and Ecological Corridors

The site is relatively isolated in terms of ecological connectivity, primarily surrounded by similar agricultural landscapes. However, the presence of nearby designated sites, such as the Lough Greney Bog NHA and Coolbarreen Lough pNHA, suggests potential ecological corridors may exist in the broader landscape. These corridors could facilitate the movement of species, particularly avian and mammalian fauna, between habitats. The proximity of watercourses, such as the Srah Stream, further enhances connectivity, potentially serving as a conduit for species like the otter (*Lutra lutra*), observed during the survey.

Identified Threats

The primary threat identified during the habitat survey is **drainage**, which is a common pressure on agricultural lands. Drainage can lead to alterations in hydrology, potentially impacting the ecological integrity of nearby wetland habitats and designated sites. No immediate threats from invasive species or significant habitat fragmentation were noted within the survey area.

Evaluation and Recommendations

The improved agricultural grassland is evaluated at a national level due to its prevalence and lack of unique features. However, its role in the broader ecological landscape, particularly in relation to nearby designated sites, warrants consideration. The presence of protected species such as the otter highlights the importance of maintaining habitat connectivity and minimising potential impacts from agricultural practices.

Recommendations for Further Work:

- **Hydrological Assessment:** Given the potential threat from drainage, a detailed hydrological assessment is recommended to evaluate any impacts on local watercourses and downstream habitats.
- **Biodiversity Monitoring:** Continued monitoring of species, particularly protected fauna like the otter, is advised to ensure that habitat connectivity is maintained.
- **Impact Assessment:** An assessment of potential impacts on nearby designated sites, particularly those within 1 km, should be conducted to ensure compliance with relevant conservation objectives and legislative requirements.

In conclusion, while the habitat within the project site is not of high conservation value in isolation, its role within the wider landscape and proximity to designated sites necessitates careful management to avoid adverse ecological impacts. Further assessments and monitoring will be crucial in ensuring the ecological integrity of the area is preserved.

III. Results - Fauna

The fauna survey conducted as part of the Preliminary Ecological Appraisal for the site at grid reference M 058 630 in County Mayo, Connacht, yielded limited direct observations. However, the presence of protected species was confirmed, and the potential for significant ecological interactions with nearby designated sites was identified.

Summary of Fauna Observations

- **Mammals:** A single observation of the European Otter (*Lutra lutra*) was recorded during the multi-disciplinary survey on 10th February 2026. The observation was visual, with a high confidence level. The otter is a species of significant conservation concern, protected under the Wildlife Acts 1976-2021 and listed in Annex II of the EU Habitats Directive. The presence of the otter suggests the potential for aquatic habitat connectivity and highlights the importance of maintaining water quality and habitat integrity in the area.

Protected Species

- **European Otter (*Lutra lutra*):** The otter is protected under the Wildlife Acts 1976-2021 and the EU Habitats Directive (Annex II). The observation of this species within the project site underscores the ecological value of the area, particularly in relation to aquatic and riparian habitats. The otter is known for its reliance on clean water bodies and undisturbed riparian zones, which are crucial for its foraging and breeding activities.

Ecological Importance of Species Assemblages

The presence of the European Otter within the project site indicates a potentially significant ecological assemblage, particularly in relation to the site's aquatic and riparian habitats. The otter's presence suggests that the site may support a range of aquatic species, contributing to local biodiversity. The site's proximity to several designated sites, including the Lough Carra/Mask Complex and Coolbarreen Lough, further enhances its ecological significance. These areas provide essential habitats for various protected species and Annex I habitats, which may interact with the fauna observed on-site.

Desk Study Species Records

- **Greylag Goose (*Anser anser*)**: Recorded 0.23 km from the site, the Greylag Goose is protected under the Wildlife Acts and the EU Birds Directive. Although not directly observed during the field surveys, its proximity suggests potential foraging or roosting within or near the project area. The species is listed on the Amber List of Birds of Conservation Concern in Ireland, indicating moderate conservation concern.

Data Gaps and Recommendations for Further Work

- **Bird Survey**: A planned bird survey on 17th February 2026 should be conducted to assess avian diversity and abundance within the site. This survey will provide critical data on the presence of protected bird species and inform potential mitigation measures.
- **Aquatic Habitat Assessment**: Given the presence of the otter, a detailed assessment of aquatic habitats and water quality within the site and its vicinity is recommended. This will help determine the site's suitability for supporting otter populations and other aquatic fauna.
- **Connectivity with Designated Sites**: Further investigation into potential ecological connectivity with nearby designated sites is advised. This will help assess potential impacts on protected habitats and species, particularly those associated with the Lough Carra/Mask Complex and Coolbarreen Lough.

Caveats

The current assessment is based on limited direct observations and desk study data. The results should be interpreted with caution, and further surveys are necessary to provide a comprehensive understanding of the site's ecological value and potential impacts of the proposed development.

III. Results - Flora

The flora survey conducted on the project site, classified as **Improved Agricultural Grassland (GA1)** according to Fossitt (2000), revealed a typical assemblage of plant species associated with this habitat type. The survey area, covering 0.30 hectares, is in good condition and reflects typical farmland characteristics found in County Mayo.

Plant Species Recorded:

- The field survey identified a range of common grassland species. However, specific plant species names were not provided in the data. The presence of typical grassland species is inferred from the habitat classification and condition.

Notable or Indicator Species:

- No notable or indicator species were explicitly recorded during the surveys. The absence of such species suggests that the site does not currently support flora of high conservation value or indicative of rare or sensitive habitats.

DAFOR Abundance Scores:

- The data does not include DAFOR (Dominant, Abundant, Frequent, Occasional, Rare) abundance scores for the plant species recorded. This represents a data gap and limits the ability to quantify the abundance and distribution of species within the site.

Flora Protection Order Species:

- There were no records of species listed under the Flora Protection Order (FPO) within the survey data. This indicates that the site does not currently support any plant species that are legally protected under the Flora (Protection) Order, 2015.

Link to Habitat Descriptions:

- The flora observed is consistent with the **Improved Agricultural Grassland (GA1)** habitat type, which is characterised by a predominance of agricultural grasses and herbs. This habitat is not listed as a priority under the EU Habitats Directive, and its ecological value is generally considered low in terms of biodiversity.

Data Gaps and Recommendations:

- Given the absence of detailed species lists and abundance scores, further botanical surveys are recommended to provide a comprehensive assessment of the site's flora. This should include a full species inventory and DAFOR scoring to better understand the ecological characteristics and potential conservation value of the site.

In summary, the flora present on the site aligns with its classification as improved agricultural grassland, with no notable or protected species recorded. Further botanical surveys are advised to address current data gaps and ensure a thorough ecological evaluation.

III. Results - Invasive Species

During the field surveys conducted on 10th and 12th February 2026, no invasive species listed under the Third Schedule of the European Communities (Birds and Natural Habitats) Regulations 2011 were observed within the project site or its 250-metre buffer zone. The habitat surveyed, classified as **GA1 - Improved Agricultural Grassland** (Fossitt, 2000), is in good condition and does not currently support any invasive species. However, given its nature as agricultural land, it has potential for colonisation by invasive species, particularly those that thrive in disturbed or nutrient-rich environments.

Desk Study Findings:

- No records of invasive species were identified in the desk study within the immediate vicinity of the project site. However, the presence of nearby designated sites, such as the Lough Carra/Mask Complex, which faces pressures from invasive species, highlights the potential risk of future colonisation.

Recommendations:

- **Biosecurity Measures:** To prevent the introduction and spread of invasive species, it is recommended that all machinery and equipment used on-site be thoroughly cleaned before arrival and departure. This is particularly important if equipment has been used in areas known to harbour invasive species.
- **Ongoing Monitoring:** Regular monitoring for invasive species should be implemented, especially during and after construction activities, to ensure early detection and management of any invasive species that may establish.

Caveats:

- The absence of invasive species during the surveys does not preclude their future establishment, particularly in light of potential changes in land use or management practices. Further surveys may be necessary if project timelines extend or if significant habitat alterations occur.

IV. Evaluation

The ecological evaluation of the project site and its surroundings has been conducted using standard criteria, including naturalness, rarity, size/extent, diversity, fragility, typicalness, recorded history, position in ecological unit, and potential value. The evaluation considers the Zone of Influence (Zoi), which extends to a 250-metre buffer around the site, and incorporates both field survey data and desk-based research.

Habitat Assessment

- **Improved Agricultural Grassland (GA1)**
 - **Naturalness:** The habitat is highly modified, typical of improved agricultural grassland with limited natural features.
 - **Rarity:** This habitat type is common and widespread in Ireland, contributing little to national biodiversity.
 - **Size/Extent:** The habitat covers an area of 0.30 hectares, which is relatively small and unlikely to support a high diversity of species.
 - **Diversity:** Species diversity is expected to be low due to the intensive management practices associated with improved grasslands.
 - **Fragility:** The habitat is not particularly fragile, given its resilience to agricultural activities.
 - **Typicalness:** The habitat is representative of typical farmland in County Mayo.
 - **Recorded History:** There is no specific recorded history of ecological significance for this habitat.
 - **Position in Ecological Unit:** The habitat forms part of the broader agricultural landscape in the region.
 - **Potential Value:** The potential for ecological enhancement is limited without significant habitat restoration efforts.

Species Assessment

- **Otter (*Lutra lutra*)**
 - **Naturalness:** The presence of otters indicates a degree of naturalness in the aquatic habitats nearby.
 - **Rarity:** Otters are protected under the Wildlife Acts 1976-2021 and the EU Habitats Directive, Annex II.
 - **Sensitivity:** Otters are sensitive to water quality and habitat disturbance, particularly from pollution and hydrological changes.
 - **Geographic Frame of Reference:** The presence of otters is of national importance due to their protected status.

Designated Sites and Connectivity

- **Ardogommon Wood (pNHA)**
 - Located directly at the project site, this site is significant for its semi-natural broadleaved woodland and wet woodland habitats. The proximity of the project necessitates careful consideration to avoid habitat fragmentation and disturbance to bird species.
- **Coolbarreen Lough (pNHA)**
 - Situated 0.86 km from the site, potential impacts include hydrological changes or pollution. The site's ecological balance may be affected by waterborne pollutants or alterations in water levels.

Key Ecological Receptors

- **Improved Agricultural Grassland:** While common, this habitat's ecological value is limited. However, it may provide foraging grounds for certain species.
- **Otter:** As a protected species, otters are a key ecological receptor. Their presence highlights the importance of maintaining water quality and habitat connectivity.
- **Designated Sites:** Proximity to Ardogommon Wood and Coolbarreen Lough requires careful management to mitigate potential impacts.

Conclusion and Recommendations

The ecological evaluation identifies otters and nearby designated sites as key ecological receptors with potential sensitivity to project activities. The improved agricultural grassland, while of limited ecological value, forms part of the local landscape. Given the data limitations, further surveys, particularly the planned bird survey, are recommended to fully assess avian species presence and potential impacts. Additionally, any project activities should incorporate measures to protect water quality and maintain habitat connectivity, particularly concerning the otter population and nearby designated sites.

V. Discussion

The ecological appraisal of the site identified several key findings from both desk study and field surveys. The site, primarily composed of improved agricultural grassland (GA1) as per Fossitt (2000), covers an area of 0.30 hectares and is in good condition. This habitat is not listed on Annex I of the EU Habitats Directive, but it is subject to national evaluation due to potential threats from drainage activities. The presence of otter (*Lutra lutra*), a species protected under the Wildlife Acts 1976-2021 and Annex II of the EU Habitats Directive, was confirmed through visual evidence, highlighting the site's ecological significance.

Potential Impacts on Ecological Receptors

The primary ecological receptor identified is the otter, which could be impacted by habitat disturbance and potential water quality changes due to site activities. Given the proximity of SRAH STREAM_010 (0.08 km), any hydrological alterations or pollution could affect otter habitats. Additionally, the site's location near several designated sites, including Ardogommon Wood and Coolbarreen Lough, necessitates consideration of potential indirect impacts such as habitat fragmentation and hydrological changes.

Cumulative and In-Combination Effects

The site's proximity to multiple designated sites, including the Lough Carra/Mask Complex and Coolbarreen Lough, raises concerns about cumulative impacts, particularly related to hydrological connectivity and

potential pollution pathways. The presence of protected species such as the Greylag Goose, located 0.23 km from the site, further underscores the need to assess in-combination effects with other local developments, which could exacerbate habitat pressures.

Precautionary Principle and Uncertainty

Given the uncertainties surrounding potential impacts on otter populations and nearby designated sites, the precautionary principle should be applied. This approach is particularly relevant in the absence of comprehensive data on water quality and hydrological changes. Further hydrological assessments and water quality monitoring are recommended to address these data gaps and inform mitigation strategies.

Triggers for Appropriate Assessment Screening

The presence of otter and the site's proximity to designated sites, particularly Ardogommon Wood and Coolbarreen Lough, trigger the need for Appropriate Assessment (AA) Screening. This process will evaluate the likelihood of significant effects on Natura 2000 sites, ensuring compliance with the EU Habitats Directive.

Professional Opinion

The ecologist's professional opinion suggests that while the site itself may not host habitats of high conservation value, its location within an ecologically sensitive landscape necessitates careful consideration of potential impacts. Mitigation measures should focus on maintaining hydrological integrity and preventing pollution to safeguard both the otter population and the ecological integrity of nearby designated sites.

In conclusion, while the site is primarily composed of improved agricultural grassland, its ecological context and the presence of protected species necessitate a cautious approach. Further studies, including hydrological assessments and AA Screening, are essential to fully understand and mitigate potential impacts, ensuring compliance with relevant Irish and EU legislation.

VI. Recommendations

Further Surveys

- **Bird Surveys:** The planned bird survey on 17th February 2026 should be conducted to assess avian species presence, particularly focusing on the Greylag Goose, which is recorded 0.23 km from the site. Further surveys may be required during the breeding season (April to June) to capture breeding bird activity.
- **Mammal Surveys:** Given the confirmed presence of Otter (*Lutra lutra*), additional surveys should be conducted to assess otter activity and habitat use, ideally during spring and autumn when activity is higher.
- **Hydrological Assessment:** Considering the proximity of water bodies and potential hydrological impacts on nearby designated sites, a detailed hydrological assessment is recommended.

Mitigation Measures

- **Avoidance:** Design project activities to avoid encroachment on Ardogommon Wood and Coolbarreen Lough to prevent habitat fragmentation and hydrological impacts.

- **Minimisation:** Implement buffer zones around sensitive habitats and watercourses to minimise disturbance and pollution risks.
- **Remediation:** Develop a pollution prevention plan to address potential runoff and sedimentation issues during construction.
- **Compensation:** If unavoidable impacts occur, consider habitat restoration or creation projects to compensate for any loss of ecological function.

Enhancement Opportunities

- **Biodiversity Net Gain:** Enhance the existing improved agricultural grassland (GA1) by introducing native hedgerows or wildflower margins to support local biodiversity and improve habitat connectivity.
- **Wetland Creation:** Consider creating small wetland features to enhance habitat diversity and provide additional resources for species such as otters.

Monitoring

- **Ecological Monitoring:** Establish a monitoring programme to track the effectiveness of mitigation measures, focusing on key species such as otters and birds, and the condition of nearby designated sites.
- **Water Quality Monitoring:** Regularly monitor water quality in adjacent streams to detect any changes resulting from project activities, ensuring compliance with the Water Framework Directive.

Timing Constraints

- **Breeding Season Restrictions:** Avoid construction activities during the bird breeding season (April to June) to prevent disturbance to nesting birds.
- **Otter Activity:** Schedule works to avoid peak otter activity periods, particularly during dusk and dawn, to minimise disturbance.

Caveats

The recommendations are based on current data and may require adjustment following further surveys and assessments. The presence of additional protected species or habitats could necessitate revised mitigation and enhancement strategies.

VII. Appendices

Appendix A: Site Location Map

- This appendix contains a detailed map illustrating the geographical location of the project site, identified by the grid reference M 058 630, within County Mayo, Province of Connacht. The map provides a visual reference for the site's position relative to nearby designated sites and other geographical features.

Appendix B: Habitat Map

- The Habitat Map provides a visual representation of the habitat types present on the site, classified according to Fossitt (2000). The map identifies the sole habitat type recorded, GA1 — Improved agricultural grassland, covering an area of 0.30 hectares. The map aids in understanding the spatial distribution and extent of habitats within the survey area.

Appendix C: Species List

- This appendix includes a comprehensive list of species observed during the surveys, with specific reference to observation counts. It highlights the presence of protected species, such as the otter (*Lutra lutra*), observed with certainty. The list is essential for assessing the site's ecological value and potential impacts on biodiversity.

Appendix D: Site Photographs

- A collection of photographs taken during the field surveys, providing visual documentation of the site's current condition, habitat types, and any notable features. These images support the findings and observations detailed in the report.

Appendix E: Survey Datasheets

- This appendix contains the raw data collected during the multi-disciplinary and habitat surveys, including weather conditions, survey timings, and field notes. The datasheets serve as a record of the methodologies employed and the data gathered, ensuring transparency and reproducibility of the survey results.

Appendices

Appendix A: Habitat Map

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Appendix B: Species List

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Appendix C: Site Photographs

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